CA/Browser Forum Tracker

What Changed, 4 to 15 October 2026

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About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. It uses several AI models from competing labs, running on different platforms. One model gathers the current claims on a topic, a different one checks each claim against its source, and disagreements are kept, not smoothed over. The aim is an even-handed account that no outside party has shaped. AI makes mistakes, and so does the system built around it. We find and fix some in every cycle, so the methods keep changing and the content should improve over time. Updates come at least quarterly, sooner if something major happens.

This update covers the CA/Browser Forum and the browser root programs from 4 October to 15 October 2026. It follows the 4 October state-of-affairs report and the full edition from the start of September. It is short because the period is short, and it reports only what moved.

Section 1 names the few changes that matter. Section 2 follows the Forum's ballots through their stages. Section 3 records who will lead the Forum from December.

Section 4 covers the root programs, the certificate authorities applying to them, and the incident record. Section 5 covers certificate lifetimes and transparency logs. Section 6 covers the standards underneath. Section 7 closes with the picture as it stood on 4 October.

1. What Matters Most

Twelve days of Forum business produced five ballot movements and one long-awaited result, and this section names the ones that change what a certificate authority must do.

The Baseline Requirements are now at version 2.3.1. The Forum's requirements page shows the new version dated 4 October [1]. The Server Certificate Working Group's agenda for 8 October states that the document was published that day [2].

The change itself is small. Ballot SC104 turns the Authority Information Access extension in subscriber certificates from a requirement into a recommendation [1]. The ballot passed its vote in September and became effective on the day it was published [1].

A ballot that had gone silent for two months finally has a result. NS-010 version 2 restructures the Network and Certificate System Security Requirements and removes expired effective dates [3]. Voting closed on 17 August, and no result was posted until 14 October [3]. It passed with all sixteen issuers and all three consumers in favour [3]. Its intellectual property review runs until 13 November [4].

The largest change for the wider ecosystem came from outside the Forum. Let's Encrypt announced on 7 October that its default certificate lifetime will fall from 90 days to 64 days on 10 February 2027 [5]. The last 90-day certificate it issues will expire on 11 May 2027 [5].

Nothing will be revoked, and clients that use the renewal information protocol need no change [5].

The fourth item is a root inclusion that stalled on its own paperwork. GoDaddy’s application to the Mozilla root store was waiting on an updated certificate practice statement [6]. GoDaddy published version 6.0 on 8 October [6]. On 15 October it confirmed that the certificate profiles in that document did not match what it actually issues, paused issuance under the affected profiles, and said it would open an incident report [6].

2. The Forum’s Ballots

A ballot passes through discussion, a seven-day vote, a thirty-day intellectual property review and publication, and only the last step makes it a rule.

Recent Developments

Two ballots entered their voting periods in the window. SMC020 removes the S/MIME requirement to record which version of the Baseline Requirements a validation method came from, aligning the S/MIME rules with an earlier server certificate change [7]. Its discussion period ran from 5 October to 12 October, and voting closes on 19 October [7]. It also adds audit log fields that would take effect on 15 March 2027 [7]. Four certificate authorities had voted in favour by 13 October [8].

CSC-034 clarifies how a natural person’s organization name appears in a code signing certificate [9]. Its discussion period ended on 14 October and its vote closes on 21 October [10]. The ballot’s purpose section cites version 3.11 of the code signing requirements while its motion says it is based on version 3.10 [9].

SC105 opened its discussion period on 14 October, to run until 21 October [11]. It removes the High Risk Certificate Request language from both the Baseline Requirements and the Extended Validation Guidelines [11]. It is written against the new version 2.3.1 [11].

Current State

The ballot on certificate problem reports, SC-107, is stuck. Its discussion period was due to end on 1 October [12]. Two weeks later the thread has 22 messages, the newest from 15 October, and no vote has been called [12]. The working group’s own agenda still lists it as under consideration [2]. The newest message concerns which certificates a certificate authority must evaluate within 120 hours of a report [12].

The ML-DSA ballot, SC-106, has changed hands. The 8 October agenda records that Amazon Trust Services is taking it over from Google Trust Services [2]. Its draft text has not changed since 31 August [13]. No post-quantum signature ballot is in any formal stage.

Two housekeeping facts remain. The requirements page shows version 2.3.1, but the Forum’s GitHub repository has no release or tag for it [14]. The newest tag is still 2.3.0 [14]. And the Code Signing Working Group’s oldest open ballot, CSC-033, has not moved since its discussion period ended in June [15].

Unresolved Conflicts

The Network Security Working Group's own ballots page still shows NS-010 as in its voting period, two days after the result was posted on the list [3] [16]. The list is the record, and the page lags it. Something similar applies to SC104, which the requirements page shows as published while the repository does not [1] [14]. The next release tag will settle it.

3. Who Runs the Forum

The Forum elects a chair and vice-chair for itself and for each working group, and the new officers take office on 1 December.

Recent Developments

The vice-chair confirmation ballot ran from 6 October to 13 October and was uncontested [17]. Tim Crawford posted the results on 15 October from nineteen ballots [17]. The Forum's vice-chair will be Karolina Ruszczynska of Certum [17]. The server certificate group's vice-chair will be Tobias Josefowitz of Opera, the only browser maker among the new officers [17]. Scott Rea of eMudhra, Dean Coclin of DigiCert, David Kluge of Google and Ben Wilson of Mozilla take the other vice-chair seats [17].

The chairs were settled earlier and the slate was corrected on 15 October [17] [18]. Dimitris Zacharopoulos of HARICA will chair the Forum [17]. Stephen Davidson of DigiCert takes the server certificate group, Rebecca Kelley of DigiCert the S/MIME group, and Martijn Katerbarg of Sectigo the code signing group [17]. Aaron Poulsen of SSL.com takes network security and Polina Glazyrina of Sectigo the definitions group [17].

Current State

DigiCert holds two chairs and one vice-chair, and Sectigo holds two chairs [17]. Among the browsers, Google, Mozilla and Opera each hold one vice-chair seat and no chair [17]. Neither election carried a ballot number, and the minutes of the September face-to-face meeting, where the chairs were chosen, are still not posted [2] [19].

4. Root Programs and Incidents

The root programs decide who is trusted, and their public bug tracker is where every failure to follow the rules is recorded.

Recent Developments

No certificate authority was admitted to any root store in the window. Besides GoDaddy's paperwork problem, eMudhra's Mozilla application is unchanged since 2 October [20]. On a separate bug, seven undisclosed subordinate authorities operated by a United Arab Emirates trust service provider were found under one of eMudhra's roots [21]. Mozilla said it had not yet implemented the distrust dates it had announced for two of eMudhra's older roots [21].

A new applicant appeared. IdenTrust opened the public discussion of nine single-purpose roots on 9 October, to run until 20 November [22]. In the other direction, two authorities asked to leave. Certigna, which stopped issuing public TLS certificates in June, asked on 13 October for

its websites trust bit to be removed [23]. Amazon Trust Services asked the same day for the Extended Validation trust bit to be removed from five of its roots [24].

Mozilla answered the question about NETLOCK's record. Ben Wilson wrote on 5 October that Mozilla is weighing the concerns as part of its assessment of the authority's continued inclusion, and will follow up publicly [25]. No action has followed.

The incident record was unusually busy. Thirty-eight compliance bugs were opened between 5 October and 15 October [26]. Thirteen are failures of the online certificate status service, filed in a wave between 8 October and 13 October after a third party sent problem reports to many authorities at once [26].

Six more concern Extended Validation test websites that did not work [26]. One stands out. GoDaddy reported issuing 54 certificates to a key it had previously recorded as compromised [27].

The registries for three country-code domains were hijacked in early October. A community count found 102 certificates issued for domains under them during the hijacks, all now blocked through Chrome's revocation list [28]. Chrome's security blog said on 6 October that the certificate authorities had not acted improperly [29]. It pointed to shorter certificate lifetimes, shorter validation reuse and its planned quantum-resistant root program as the answers, without new dates [29].

Current State

No root program took a distrust or removal action in the window [26]. The Mozilla, Chrome, Apple and Microsoft policy repositories had no commits at all between 2 October and 15 October [30]. Apple's draft Merkle Tree Certificate policy, promised by the end of October, has not appeared [31].

Unresolved Conflicts

GoDaddy's approval was due to follow seven days after its new practice statement [6]. Its own admission that the document did not match its issuance now stands between it and the root store, and the incident report it promised is not yet filed [6]. How long the delay runs depends on that report.

5. Shorter Certificates and Transparency

Certificate lifetimes are falling by rule and by choice, and every public certificate must appear in logs whose operators are themselves held to a standard.

Recent Developments

Let's Encrypt's 64-day announcement comes with a schedule for the years after [5]. Reuse of a domain authorization falls from 30 days to 10 days with the new lifetime, and to 7 hours in 2028, when the default lifetime falls again to 45 days [5]. The staging environment switched to 64-day certificates on 14 October [5]. The authority also announced two more remote network perspectives for domain validation, making six, ahead of the Forum rule that requires five from 15 December [32]. They reach staging on 27 October and production on 10 November [32].

Chrome's transparency log list moved from version 93.3 to 95.1 [33]. Sixteen logs were admitted, covering HARICA's new Selene logs for 2027 and 2028, Sectigo's Monument and Statue logs, and Let's Encrypt's Sycamore and Willow logs for 2028 [33]. Apple's list rejected fifteen shards for the first half of 2026 on 5 October, as those periods closed [34].

The new HARICA logs stumbled at once. Selene missed its merge deadline on 12 October and again on 14 October, with six short outages on the second day [35]. A preliminary report came on 15 October with the root cause still open [35]. Cloudflare archived its 2025 Nimbus log on 13 October [36].

Current State

Work on Merkle Tree Certificates continued without a new policy. The community specifications were tagged at version 0.1.0 on 7 October, and the IETF draft reached revision 07 the same day [37] [38]. Let's Encrypt's issuance software is landing the code to issue them [39]. Chrome and Cloudflare published nothing new in the window.

6. Standards Underneath

The Forum's documents cite IETF standards, so a draft becoming a numbered RFC changes what the Baseline Requirements may reference.

Recent Developments

The composite signature draft, which pairs ML-DSA with a conventional algorithm in one certificate, reached final review at the RFC Production Center on 14 October [40]. That is the last stage before the authors' sign-off, and it is still not an RFC [40]. The composite key encapsulation draft was approved on 12 October and joined the queue [41].

The two TLS drafts that put ML-KEM and ML-DSA directly into the protocol had been on hold since 24 September. The hold was lifted on 5 October and both await an editor [42]. The reason for the hold is not recorded [42]. The ACME draft on account-bound domain labels moved to its area director's evaluation and was sent back for a revision on 14 October [43].

Current State

No change touched the certificate authority authorization records, and no errata were filed against the core certificate profile standard in 2026 [44].

7. Where Things Stood on 4 October

The 4 October report told the longer story, and this section recalls enough of it to read the update.

The September edition and the 4 October report described a Forum whose main question was who will issue certificates when the web moves to post-quantum signatures. Chrome and Apple had each announced a separate trust path built on Merkle Tree Certificates, Cloudflare had applied to become a certificate authority, and Microsoft had deployed pilot roots using ML-DSA. The Forum's own ML-DSA ballot had draft text and no sponsor movement.

On the rules side, the Baseline Requirements stood at version 2.3.0. SC104 had passed its vote and become effective on 4 October, but its text had not yet been published. The S/MIME requirements had just reached version 1.0.16, with a new rule on extended key usage taking effect in July 2027. The code signing requirements stood at version 3.11.0, effective since 15 September. NS-010 had been voted on in August with no result announced.

Among the root programs, Mozilla had signalled its intent to approve GoDaddy and eMudhra, with last calls ending 9 October. A question about NETLOCK's incident handling was open. Nineteen compliance bugs had been filed in the preceding week, most about revocation lists. The transparency log list stood at version 93.3, and GoDaddy had just become a log operator.

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